SIMTERNSHIP SUCCESS GUIDE

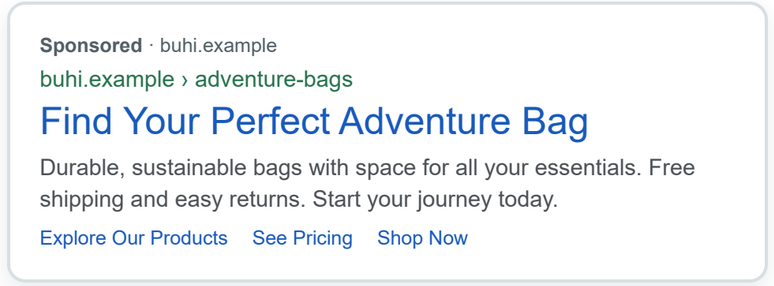
How to Succeed in the Digital Marketing Simternship in 2026 at Vanderbilt

Use these best practices to create polished, persuasive, performance-ready search ads and make smarter bidding decisions in the simulation.

Prepared for Vanderbilt digital marketing students | Updated for the 2026 course

Crafting impactful search ads is one of your most important Simternship tasks. Your ads appear in search results and compete for attention in a fast-moving space. Every ad should capture attention, match the landing page, and give the intended customer a reason to click.

The guide below focuses on five qualities of strong search ads, followed by a bidding strategy and final pre-launch checklist.



Writing a Quality Search Ad

1. Call-to-Action (CTA)

Your CTA should be clear, direct, and action-oriented. A strong CTA helps convert interest into clicks.

Shop | Order Now | Learn More | Get Started | Request a Quote | Download | Try for Free | Start Today | See Pricing | Add to Cart

> **Tip:** Tailor the CTA to the buyer-journey stage. Are they browsing, comparing, or ready to purchase?

2. Highlight Product Benefits

Benefits make the offer appealing. Tell potential customers why they should click and what sets the product apart.

Free Shipping | Sustainable Materials | Free Returns | 15-inch Laptop Sleeve | Durable Fabric | Perfect for Travel | 24/7 Support

> **Best practice:** Highlight a meaningful differentiator while staying concise.

3. Relevance to the Landing Page

A quality ad does not stop at the click. It prepares the visitor for the landing-page experience.

- Use language that matches the page's keywords, CTA, and benefits.
- Reinforce the same product benefit or offer.
- Make the transition from ad to page seamless and trustworthy.

4. Keyword Relevance

Search ads depend on keywords to match user intent.

- Use relevant keywords in headlines and descriptions.
- Choose keywords that match the persona and product.
- Avoid vague terms; specific language is better.

> **Example:** Replace “bag” with “lightweight hiking backpack with laptop sleeve.”

5. Grammar and Spelling

Typos and poor grammar damage credibility instantly. Every ad should be professionally written, free from errors, clear, and concise.

> **Review tip:** Read the ad aloud to catch awkward phrasing and missed punctuation.

Bidding Strategy: Make Smart Investment Choices

Adjust your bid based on keyword competitiveness.

Competition	Recommended Strategy
Non-Competitive	Bid at or close to the suggested amount; focus on efficiency and relevance.
Low	Bid at or close to the suggested amount and strengthen the ad copy.
Medium	Bid 3-5% higher.
High	Bid 10-15% higher.

Final Pre-Launch Checklist

- Have I included a clear CTA?
- Did I mention at least one strong product benefit?
- Is the language consistent with the landing page?
- Are relevant keywords used in key placements?
- Is the grammar and spelling correct?
- Did I apply the right bidding strategy?